

Secrecy Shrouds 'Black' Bases Budget

BY DAVID C. MORRISON
Special to The Chronicle

Analysis of Pentagon budget documents shows that from fiscal 1985-89, \$500 million will have been spent building or improving "black" bases, secret facilities designed to support such activities as stealth aircraft operations, contingency facilities for Middle Eastern conflicts, hosting special operations units, electronic spy stations, and even combat hospitals stashed away in tunnels.

A rough picture of the black base infrastructure can be gleaned from the often elliptical descriptions found in the 4,000-pages of "justification of budget estimate" documents sent up to Capital Hill every year to support military construction requests.

Still, the paucity of data published about some projects renders their function a complete mystery to the uninitiated. Over the past five years, for instance, the Army has received \$20.3 million for construction described only as covering "classified activities at various locations." Often, such requests are cited simply as being for a "special project," a favorite euphemism for black activities.

Black bases are a little-discussed aspect of a much larger phenomenon — the Pentagon's burgeoning black budget.

In the fiscal 1988 budget approved last December, according to National Journal calculations, black spending for top-secret procurement and research and development projects totaled a hefty \$20.6 billion — 17 percent of all the money in the procurement and research and development accounts — as compared with only \$5.5 billion in fiscal 1981. The Defense Department's fiscal 1989 budget request would see those black funds grow by another 14 percent, to \$23.5 billion.

The soaring black budget for procurement and research is driven largely by the

David C. Morrison is on the staff of the National Journal, where this article first appeared. Reprinted with permission

accelerating momentum of rapidly maturing and increasingly costly stealth projects — aircraft and missiles designed to evade detection by enemy radar and infrared sensors.

Though black construction climbed from \$4.6 million to \$134.5 million over that seven-year period, it is much less volatile than the other black budget categories. Over the past five years, actual spending for black construction has typically run about \$100 million, or a little more than 1 percent of the total military construction budget — which is \$8.7 billion for fiscal 1988.

Often, however, a classified military construction project represents only the tip of a black iceberg. The description of a fiscal 1988 \$3 million request for an electrical substation at a classified U.S. location, for example, notes that it is for a project worth \$124 million all told.

Moreover, black bases don't just sit idle; they contribute to the growth of classified personnel accounts — from which the estimated 25,000 employees of the National Security Agency (NSA) are paid — as well as black operations and maintenance accounts.

A rare glimpse into the opaque black operations budget was provided during a House Armed Services Committee hearing last year.

Charts displayed by Air Force comptroller General Claudius E. Watts III showed that the classified operations costs for his service's intelligence programs would hit \$603 million in fiscal 1988, while the tab for black operations for Air Force tactical forces would almost double from fiscal 1987 to 1988, reaching \$202 million. Classified programs, Watts testified, are one of the "biggest drivers" of the operations budget.

The most intriguing of the Pentagon's black bases may be those associated with the stealth program. Many analysts believe that the \$162.4 million in construction funds appropriated from fiscal 1985-88 for something called the Special Tacti-

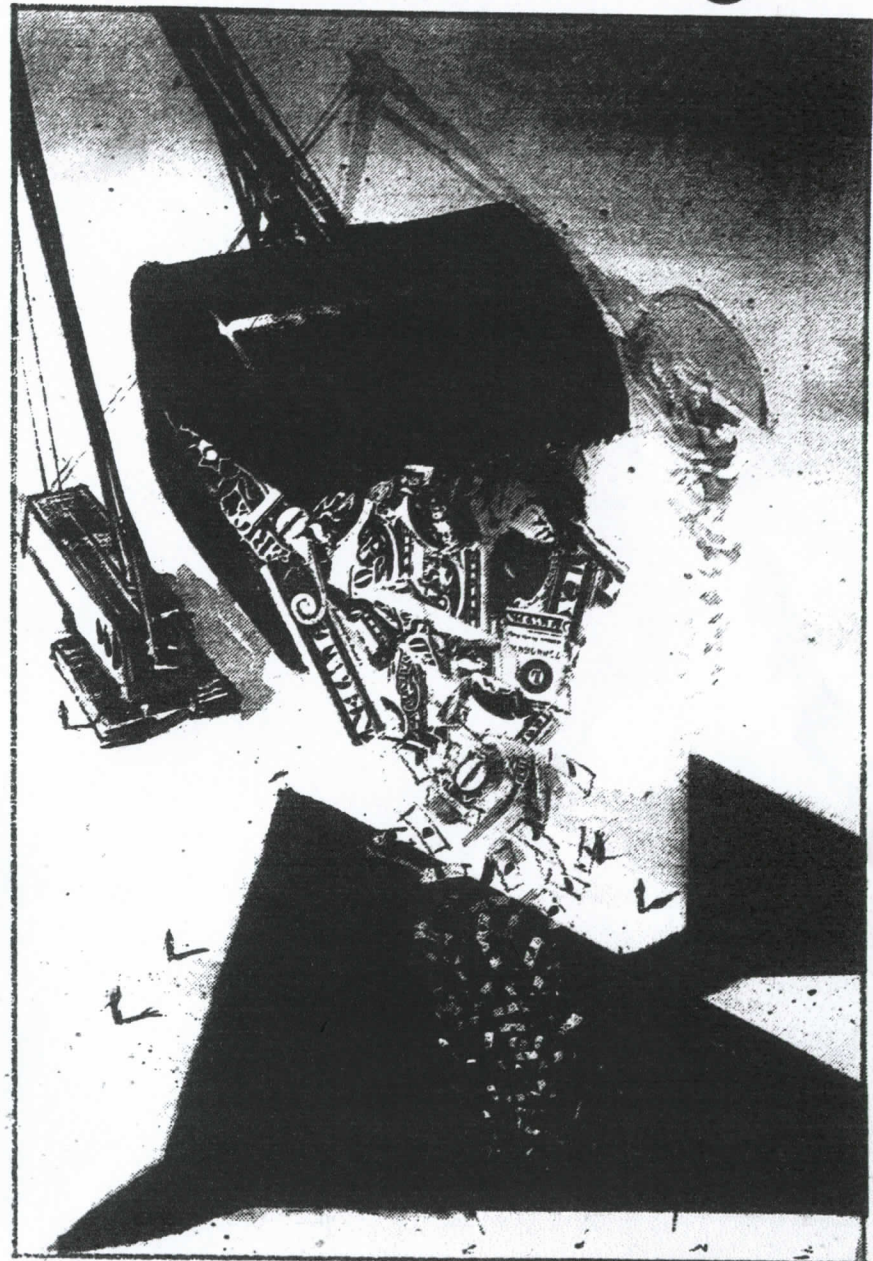


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cal Detachment — described only as a "special project" — is basing money for the Air Force's unacknowledged stealth fighter, often called the F-19.

"That sounds like just about the right timing for the stealth base, which was expanding at that time," said Bill Sweetman, author of "Stealth Aircraft: Secrets of Future Airpower."

The F-19s are reputedly housed at the Tonopah Test Range, a top-secret facility in the Nevada desert, where about four dozen white hangars with red doors, a control tower and a 13,000-foot runway have recently been built.

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Legend has it that the fighters fly only under the cover of night and that pilots are under orders to land only at Tonopah. Should that prove impossible, they are then to ditch their aircraft so as to destroy them. In July 1986, what is believed to be one of the Tonopah stealth birds crashed and burned near Bakersfield, Calif.

Basing arrangements for the B-2 stealth bomber are less mysterious; the Air Force announced last year that the first B-2 facility would be at Whiteman Air Force Base, Mo. The \$89.3 million requested for "special mission support" at a "Base 75" last year thus turned out to be a downpayment for the B-2 base. This year, the Air Force has come back for another \$84.3 million; total B-2 basing costs at Whiteman will run about \$700 million.

Thanks to "special maintenance and security requirements," the service will build a covered hangar for each of the 34 B-2s destined for Whiteman, as well as a covered shelter for each B-2 on armed alert.

What puzzles analysts, however, is why the Air Force wants to keep the B-2 under continuous cover when it has already released a drawing of the bat-shaped plane and is planning a public "roll-out" ceremony for the first B-2 in August.

"One possibility is that the Air Force sees a crucial distinction between allowing reporters to snap a few photographs at a ceremony and Soviet satellites scrutinizing the \$450 million aircraft at their leisure.

Another key to the shelter mystery may lie in an Air Force statement this year that the B-2's "low observable features require frequent performance of structural and propulsion maintenance activities." Technicians will "have these things disassembled and in pieces on the floor all the time," Federation of American Scientists analyst John E. Pike predicted. "They'll be a bitch to maintain."

The Air Force refuses to discuss total basing costs for all 132 B-2s, which could top \$2 billion — if the bill for Whiteman is any indication. The service, in fact, is as close-mouthed about B-2 basing as it is about other aspects of the \$60 billion program.

After the Air Force, which accounts for half of the \$500 million in fiscal 1985-89 covert construction funds, the National Security Agency consumes the largest share: about \$141.3 million. The intensely private NSA busies itself suctoning up and analyzing other countries' electronic communications.

Eavesdropper's Empire

A sense of the data burden generated by this global eavesdropping mission is suggested by NSA's fiscal 1989 request for a \$4.9 million "waste destruct facility" to provide "additional incineration capacity" at a classified site — most likely its Ft. Meade, Md., headquarters.

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Inadvertently, the fiscal 1985 House Armed Services Committee markup report revealed that \$500,000 for an electrical substation at a classified location was, in fact, destined for Rosman, N.C.

It turns out that NSA operates the so-called Rosman Research Station, a 250-person facility in the Great Smokey Mountains. Up until 1981 a National Aeronautics and Space Administration spaceflight tracking station, Rosman is now a "dish farm," pulling down and decoding signals from satellites passing overhead.

In addition to the dedicated NSA facilities, the military services also operate an estimated 60 electronic intelligence collection stations of their own as part of the NSA's Central Security Service.

Middle East Missions

Another driver of the black bases budget has been the commitment first under-taken by President Carter to maintain a capability to intervene militarily in the Middle East. This requirement sparked a minor flap in 1983 when then-deputy assistant defense secretary for Near Eastern and South Asian affairs, Air Force Major General Richard Secord, now an Iran-contra affair defendant, revealed in congressional testimony that the United States had a secret, 100-man base in southern Egypt that could support

two fighter squadrons.

The Egyptians had asked that the base be kept secret, Secord said, because no formal agreement had been signed and they "will not give one."

The next year, the Army asked for \$69.2 million for another contingency facility "for a company-sized unit with aircraft" in an undisclosed country in the region. Congress nixed the request because a "country-to-country agreement" had not been signed.

In 1986, the Army requested \$4.9 million to build storage facilities at a classified Middle Eastern location "to properly safeguard millions of dollars worth of supplies."

Noting that more than \$1.1 billion had already been spent since 1980 on rapid-deployment-related bases in Diego Garcia, Kenya, Morocco, Oman, Portugal and Somalia, the House Appropriations Committee turned down the request, saying that it "views the Persian Gulf facility program as virtually complete in that no new major projects or sites are envisioned."

Classified Storage Sites

This year, however, the Army is back with two more requests for unspecified Middle Eastern sites: \$4.5 million for a storage facility and \$17.5 million for an "intermediate staging area." The latter, the Army reports, "will provide a location where the deploying units can assemble, complete training, acclimatize and prepare for commitment to the combat zone."

The defense budget is rife with secret storage sites. Two years ago, the Navy got \$15.7 billion to construct 40 secure ammunition magazines "for contingency operations"

at a secret site in Europe, and the Air Force received \$11.5 million for a European storage facility geared to a "special project."

"The list of weapons storage sites was always classified," recalled retired Rear Admiral Eugene J. Carroll Jr., deputy director of the Center for Defense Information, a private Washington advocacy group, who served in a senior NATO post in the late 1970s. "On the other hand, it would be difficult to keep them entirely a secret because they are part of the community."

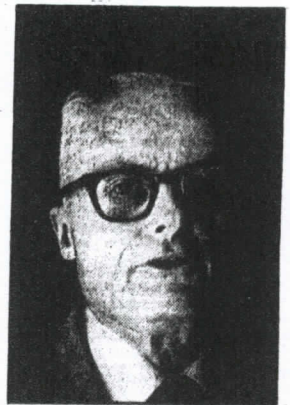
Most overseas black base requests state that the projects are ineligible for NATO money. The reason, Carroll said, is that all NATO-financed projects must come under NATO supervision.

"There is zero eligibility for NATO funding for NSA facilities," he said, by way of example. "We would close the doors and bar the windows and put up electronic surveillance devices and so on. It would be purely national." Likewise for special operations forces, Carroll added, which "are the only element of U.S. forces in Europe that do not chop (transfer) to NATO as part of the alert schedule. As a result, any funding would be strictly U.S."

This year, the Navy is asking for \$4.9 million to build an overseas base for Naval Special Warfare Unit (NSWU) 6. This unit, to be commissioned next year, will consist of 66 elite SEAL commandos equipped with James Bond-like underwater propulsion units and be based at

"classified, secure and permanent facilities including a remote waterfront location."

Three smaller units are already based overseas: NSWU 1 at Subic Bay in the Philippines, NSWU 2 at Machirhanish in Scotland and NSWU 4 at Roosevelt Roads in Puer-



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however, about its \$7.1 million fiscal 1989 request to greatly expand — to 208 commandos and 18 patrol boats — a Special Boat Unit set up in Panama in 1987. This growth, it says, is aimed at bolstering protection of the canal and U.S. personnel assigned to Panama.

Though special operations can be expected to be classified, aspects of the Pentagon's recently accelerated combat casualty care initiative are also surprisingly black.

The Air Force, for instance, is requesting \$12.8 million to build a 500-bed medical contingency complex next year at a location in Europe designated as Base 54. The Air Force has already placed 11 such hospitals in Europe, out of 23 purchased.

Numbers, Not Names

"All those facilities fit into the worldwide stationing plan for contingency facilities and our part of the war-planning effort, much of which is classified," Gordon Dowery, director of the Pentagon's medical facilities office, told Congress last year.

The mushrooming growth of black Pentagon research and procurement programs has generated mounting controversy, as well as some mildly restraining legislation. Black military construction projects, by contrast, have attracted little attention — largely, it seems, because they have remained at a fiscal plateau.

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